became apparent as soon as we landed in Mumbai. It was around dawn and the arrivals area was pretty deserted. We got our bags, walked over to the guy at the customs area, who promptly snapped to attention, saluted, and very enthusiastically said, ‘Welcome to India, Mr Gibbs!’ And that was just the start of the kind of attention my visit to India attracted.

Peter and I walked outside … and straight into around 1 000 members of the press – photographers, TV crews and journos. This was 6 a.m. in the morning. It really threw me, and even though we were met by our team manager, Goolam Rajah, and one of the team’s security guards, Faizal (fantastic oke), I was pretty spooked. With Faizal on point guard, we basically had to shoulder charge our way to the car. It all really drove home the fact that it didn’t matter how well I knew my shit, I was still going to be facing what appeared to be some very fired-up Indian fellows.

Now, given that I would be flying to Delhi the next morning, you’d have thought I probably had an early night to leave myself fresh and ready for battle, right? Ja. No.

I proceeded to get absolutely smashed at a bar around the corner from the Taj Hotel, where we were staying.

In the bar, I apparently became closely acquainted with a very friendly German girl, and she and I indulged in a little tonsil hockey right there in front of the other patrons. I say ‘apparently’, because I don’t remember any of it. Faizal had witnessed the scene. ‘That was one serious show you put on for us in the bar last night,’ Faizal said on the aeroplane the morning after. I was like, ‘What are you talking about?’ This, by the way, was after Faizal had to just about break down my hotel-room door to wake me up. I managed to have a quick shower and get on the plane in time.

Faizal told me that apparently I had also arranged to meet the girl back at the Taj Hotel’s nightclub, but when she pitched up – who knows why – I had ignored her. The girl broke down in tears. (If this book ever gets translated into German and she reads it, I hereby apologise for my rude behaviour.)

Pete had taken one look at me that morning – no doubt he was smelling me too … it gets hot in India – and said, ‘Hersch, have some bladdy breakfast, and catch an hour’s sleep. That’s going to help you way more than us going over this stuff again.’

The South African High Commissioner in Delhi, Francis Moloi, met us at the airport – I think the Indians were pretty taken aback when I turned up